University of Michigan
Ann Arbor Essay Playbook

College of Engineering applicant edition

Exemplar essays and breakdowns gathered from College Essay Guy, Crimson Education, Quad Education Group, CollegeVine, GradPilot and others, plus a fill-in-the-blank structure for:

- **Essay #1** — Leaders and citizens who “challenge the present and enrich the future” (300 words)
- **Essay #2** — Why the College of Engineering, and how its curriculum supports your interests (550 words)

Read this first: what this PDF is and is not

I searched the sites you named and several others. **Very few sites publish full, verified winning UMich essays.** Most publish short excerpts, summaries, or writer-made samples, and the text I could retrieve was limited to brief quotes. So this guide gives you, for each exemplar: where it came from, what it does, short excerpts, and a close analysis. Full texts are behind the links in the Sources section; read them there alongside this guide. I did **not** invent essays and label them as real. Where a sample was written by the site as a demonstration, I say so.

Also: I couldn't find a College Essay Guy engineering-specific UMich sample. Their page covers the two prompts through LSA-style and general examples (one Prompt 2 example is climate science), so the engineering analysis leans on the Crimson engineering essay and my read of the patterns. Course and team names (ENGR 100, ME 240, etc.) come from third-party sample essays and **must be checked on engin.umich.edu** before you use them.

Part 1. The prompts, decoded

Essay #1 — Leaders and citizens (300 words max)

> *"...share with us how you are prepared to contribute to these goals. This could include the people, places, experiences or aspirations that have shaped your journey and future plans."*

- **Two jobs:** (1) prove preparation with **things you actually did**, and (2) point forward to what you will do. Admissions readers care about evidence at the scale you really operated at, not a manifesto.
- **College Essay Guy's frame:** treat it as a **community essay**. Map your communities (place, action, interest, circumstance), then run the BEABIES questions: What did you *do* (active verbs)? What problem did you solve? What was the impact? What did you learn? How did you apply it?
- **Structure choice:** if you faced a challenge, use a **narrative** (challenge, response, lesson, future). If not, use a **montage** (2-3 short moments tied by one value).
- **Work backwards** (CollegeAdvisor): start from your future goal, ask why it matters and where it came from, then build the essay on the one experience that explains it.
- Choose **one** thread from the prompt's menu (person, place, experience, aspiration) and follow it into your future. Do not try to cover everything in 300 words.

Essay #2 — Why Michigan Engineering (550 words max)

> *"Describe the unique qualities that attract you to the specific undergraduate College or School... How would that curriculum support your interests?"*

- **Don't** write about rankings, weather, football, location or reputation. Michigan already knows. Don't paraphrase the website.
- **Do** write about *yourself* too. It is a two-way fit: what you bring, and what you'd use.
- **Three specifics with reasons beat ten in a list** (GradPilot). Every resource you name needs a "because" tied to something you have done or value.
- **Name-swap test** (SayHelloCollege): if you can replace "Michigan" with another school and the essay still works, it isn't specific enough.
- College Essay Guy's outline: hook, thesis (what you'll study and why), two offerings in your field connected to you, one offering outside your field, your most important extracurricular, a brief closing.
- Apply to the college you write about. Readers notice a mismatch between your chosen college and your essay.

Part 2. Exemplars for Essay #1 (Leaders and Citizens / Community)

Each entry: source, summary, short excerpt where available, analysis. Word counts are given where the source reported them.

Exemplar 1A — “The Rent Notice” (292 words)

Source: AdmissionSight, UMich Supplemental Essays. Prompt 1.

What it does: Opens in a single concrete scene, a rent-increase notice on the family kitchen table. Moves from that moment to AP Macro/Micro/Statistics, the High School Fed Challenge and National Economics Challenge, and independent research on cost-of-living pressures. Ends on a goal: designing and evaluating policies that reduce economic precarity in work, housing and healthcare.

> *Excerpt: “The notice was folded once before my father set it on the kitchen table.”*

Why it works

- The scene makes the ambition feel earned, not abstract.
- Preparation is shown through **tools built** (analysis, research), not just a problem named.
- Moves personal -> community -> future, which is exactly the prompt's arc.

What to borrow / what to improve

- Borrow: open on a quiet object in a specific place, not a big statement.
- Borrow the pivot sentence type: “things don't have to be this way,” followed by what you did to understand why.
- Improve: add one line on what you'd do *at Michigan*.

Exemplar 1B — Water Filtration Campaign

Source: College Essay Guy, UMich guide (Example 1B). Prompt 1.

What it does: Student and an environmental club push for filtered water stations. The school board rejects the proposal; they crowdfund, win the stations, and measure environmental and social results.

Why it works

- Vivid opening scene establishes the problem and the writer's role fast.
- Honest about the **setback** (board rejection), which adds vulnerability and persistence.
- Shows individual role inside a group, plus lasting, measurable impact.
- Closes by circling back to an image from the opening.

What to borrow / what to improve

- Borrow: the rejection-then-workaround beat. It is the strongest 'leader' move in 300 words.
- Borrow the circle-back ending.
- Improve (per the author): add forward-looking detail about how you'd keep acting in college.

Exemplar 1C — Bahrain Heritage Day

Source: College Essay Guy, UMich guide (Example 1A). Prompt 1.

What it does: A student is questioned about their Pakistani identity at a school event in Bahrain. That moment sparks inclusivity work through leadership roles, an environmental club and service projects, ending with a link to a specific campus service center.

Why it works

- Context is brief, so most words go to **actions, impact, growth**.
- Named activities extend the activities list and show an experience turning into action.
- The campus link makes it a mini 'why Michigan.'

What to borrow / what to improve

- Borrow: one sentence of context, then verbs.
- Borrow: end with a named Michigan community you'd join (e.g., Edward Ginsberg Center, a student org) and what you'd do there.

Exemplar 1D — Camp Counselor at a Free After-School Program

Source: Quad Education Group, annotated excerpt. Prompt 1.

What it does: A camp counselor describes kids who became like family through art projects, writing practice and Xbox tournaments.

> *Excerpt: "The kids became family; through sarcophagus art projects, writing practice, Xbox tournaments..."*

Why it works

- Pulls the reader in from the first line.
- Shows real relationships and a leadership role without saying 'I am a leader.'
- Brief but memorable; the specific list ("sarcophagus art projects, writing practice, Xbox tournaments") is the personality.

What to borrow / what to improve

- Borrow: a concrete, slightly surprising list of 3 details that no one else could write.
- Improve: add what changed in *you* and what you'll do next.

Exemplar 1E — Coaching the Underdogs (300 words)

Source: CollegeVine, UMich essay examples (Example 1). Community prompt.

What it does: Summer junior basketball team of inexperienced players: losing start, heart-to-heart, close playoff loss, parents thanking the coach. Setup, struggle, turnaround, reflection.

Why it works

- Leadership role and love of teaching are clear.
- Proves everyday groups make strong community essays.

What to borrow / what to improve

- Reviewer's fix: show more, tell less. Open *inside* the playoff game and replace summary sentences with scenes.
- Lesson for you: don't open with 'I coach a team'; open with the moment.

Exemplar 1F — Drawing Class

Source: CollegeVine (Example 2). 300 words.

What it does: Playful hook about staring into the eyes of a drawing, then art class as a community, the writer as supportive helper rather than star, ending on vulnerability.

> *Excerpt: “Art breeds vulnerability, and vulnerability breeds connection.”*

Why it works

- Unusual hook and vivid language.
- Self-positioning as supporter, not star, is distinctive.

What to borrow / what to improve

- Borrow the line shape: “Art breeds vulnerability, and vulnerability breeds connection.” (short parallel sentence that states the lesson). Use this once, not three times.
- Improve: one fuller anecdote with an outcome.

Exemplar 1G — Books and the Book Bus

Source: CollegeVine (Example 3). 300 words.

What it does: A reading life (Jane Eyre, Harry Potter), then discovering not all kids have books, then a small book bus and reading workshops. Personal escape becomes community action.

> *Excerpt: “I've played with magic, lived in dystopian societies, and traveled the world, all through a flip of a page.”*

Why it works

- Curiosity, empathy and initiative in one arc.
- Concrete numbers (about ten books, one town) keep it honest.

What to borrow / what to improve

- Borrow: the 'I loved X, then I noticed who didn't have it' turn.
- Improve: show direct interactions with others and a timeline so we see how you changed.

Exemplar 1H — Hardware Store Returns Desk (constructed sample)

Source: GradPilot. ***Written by the site as a demonstration, not an admitted student.*** *Prompt 1.*

What it does: Student notices a flawed refund policy at the family store, fixes it with a one-page proposal, and links it to public policy interest.

Why it works

- Annotation: answers 'prepared to contribute' with one act at its real scale and reaches 'future plans' in the last line.

What to borrow / what to improve

- Lesson: small, real, and specific beats grand and vague.
- The annotation itself says it still needs a sentence on Michigan.

Part 3. Exemplars for Essay #2 (Why this College)

Exemplar 2A — “The Garage” Mechanical Engineering (515 words) — MOST RELEVANT TO YOU

Source: AdmissionSight. College of Engineering, Prompt 2.

What it does: Opens in a garage repairing a hinge on a homemade bike trailer. The repair sparks interest in mechanical engineering. Then names specific courses (ENGR 100, ME 240, ME 250, ME 211), project teams (MRover, Formula SAE), the Walter E. Lay Automotive Laboratory and the Wilson Student Team Project Center, explaining how each deepens design and testing skills. Ends on a goal: clean energy systems that cut household energy costs in communities affected by pollution.

> *Excerpt: “The smell of hot metal and motor oil hung in the garage as the drill whined against aluminum.”*

Why it works

- The personal narrative proves genuine interest **before** the major is named, so Michigan Engineering feels like the natural next step.
- Research is visible: courses, teams, labs, each followed by what it does for the writer.
- Shape: interest and roots, then named Michigan resources, then why they matter, then a mission.

What to borrow / what to improve

- Borrow the sensory opener: sound, smell, tool, material. Engineering readers want to see hands-on curiosity.
- Borrow the endpoint: a people-centered goal (communities, households), not just 'I love machines.'
- Verify every course/team name yourself; do not copy a list from a sample.

Exemplar 2B — Climate Policy and Science

Source: College Essay Guy (Example 2B). LSA-style, but the structure transfers.

What it does: Opens with a quote from a friend, explains a plan to combine science and policy, names campaign volunteering, courses, professors and their research, a planned minor, plus outdoor and student government interests.

Why it works

- Quote works because it is specific, personal and not widely used, and the writer explains what it means.
- Professor, course and program names show how resources will be used.
- Non-academic interests show a whole person.

What to borrow / what to improve

- Borrow: tie each Michigan resource to a stated value.
- Engineering adaptation: replace policy courses with an interdisciplinary track (e.g., energy, sustainability, robotics) and cite a lab whose work matches your project.

Exemplar 2C — Creative Writing and Asian Studies

Source: College Essay Guy (Example 2A).

What it does: Opens by comparing to famous fantasy writers, then gives each interest its own paragraph with seminars, language programs, study abroad and student groups. Mentions openness to business or

law and past contact with Michigan faculty.

Why it works

- Each interest gets one paragraph with specifics: easy to follow.
- Naming other possibilities shows range without losing focus.
- Prior contact with the university shows commitment.

What to borrow / what to improve

- Borrow: one paragraph per interest.
- Borrow: mention that you emailed or met a faculty member, attended a visit day or webinar, if true.

Exemplar 2D — Economics, LSA and the Ford School

Source: Quad Education Group excerpt.

What it does: Traces economics interest from a junior-year microeconomics class to a poverty focus. Cites volunteering for a local representative, Ford School events and Poverty Solutions. Closes: “I want to join the University of Michigan's legacy of innovators.”

> *Excerpt: “I want to join the University of Michigan's legacy of innovators.”*

Why it works

- Gets to the central issue quickly.
- Connects extracurriculars to future goals and ends by tying programs back to aspiration.

What to borrow / what to improve

- Borrow: the 'legacy' close, adapted to engineers (e.g., the Michigan tradition of building things that leave the lab and reach people).
- Avoid: a closing line with no sensory detail. Try to end on an image.

Exemplar 2E — Political Science and Environment (LSA, 550 words)

Source: CollegeVine (Example 4).

What it does: Opens with a striking statistic quote from a legislative speech tied to a June 2022 committee experience; then LSA's interdisciplinary appeal, the Residential College, Honors, a research lab, Michigan in Washington, debate and advisory board.

Why it works

- Specific, personal research; resources connected to goals without a bullet-list feel.

What to borrow / what to improve

- Reviewer: last paragraph too dense; ~50 words unused. Use extra words on transitions that link your opener to later points.
- Lesson: use your full 550, but with air between ideas.

Exemplar 2F — Psychology and Spanish (LSA)

Source: CollegeVine (Example 5).

What it does: Frames identity first (“an aspiring trilingual clinical psychologist”), then courses, a named lab, an honors thesis, and study abroad.

Excerpt: “a scholar with a heart for service”

Why it works

- Memorable identity statement; each detail has a why; avoids name-dropping.

What to borrow / what to improve

- Reviewer: organized by program type; reorganizing around **your values** would be more cohesive.
- Borrow: a one-phrase identity such as 'a builder who designs for people' (put your own here).

Bonus — Ross business prompts (different college, useful for tone)

CollegeVine's Ross examples (a peer-support app born from an eating-disorder struggle; a first school newspaper article about Disney princesses) both succeed on **honesty and self-awareness** and lose points for repetitive structure and vague phrases like “a different light.” Lesson: define every abstract phrase and include at least one fully told anecdote.

Part 4. What the winners have in common

Tone

- **Plain, concrete, first-person.** Short sentences next to one longer one. No thesaurus words.
- **Quietly confident, not boastful.** The best essays let actions carry the leadership claim.
- **Earnest but with a little humor or surprise** (the Xbox tournaments, the drawing hook).
- **Vulnerable once**: one honest setback or doubt (rejected proposal, unpublished app).

Wording patterns you can model

- Open on **object + place + sense**: “The smell of hot metal...”, “The notice was folded once...”
- Use **active verbs**: built, rewired, drafted, pitched, rebuilt, tested, taught, organized.
- Name **numbers and proper nouns** (a 20,000 sq ft workshop, ten books, 150 students). Specificity is the whole game.
- Use a **pivot sentence** at the midpoint: “What I didn't expect was...” / “That's when I realized...” (use once).
- For Michigan resources: **[name] + 'where I would' + [verb] + [because of your prior experience]**.
- Close with an **image or action**, not a slogan.

Structure at a glance

	Essay #1 (300)	Essay #2 (550)
Open	Scene (40-55 words)	Scene or object (70-90 words)
Middle	Action + setback + result (120-140)	Interest -> 3 named Michigan specifics, each with a 'because' (280-320)
Turn	What you learned (40-50)	Something outside the major + your involvement (50-70)
Close	Forward to Michigan (40-50)	Mission + image (50-70)

Common mistakes the reviewers flagged

- Summary instead of scenes (“show more, tell less”).
- Vague phrases (“unique lenses”) with no definition.
- Listing resources with no link to you.
- Two essays repeating the same story. Essay #1 is **who you've been**, Essay #2 is **what you'll build here**.
- Dense final paragraph; unused word count.

Part 5. Your fill-in-the-blank structures

Replace every {curly brace}. The prompts after each paragraph tell you what to put in. Keep the sentence shapes; change the content. Word budgets are in brackets. Do not submit anything with braces left in.

ESSAY #1 TEMPLATE — Leaders and Citizens (target 285-300 words)

Paragraph 1: Scene [~50 words]

{insert time and place, e.g., 'At 6:40 a.m. in our school's cold workshop'}, {insert imagery details: one sound, one smell, one object}. {Insert the problem in one plain sentence: who was affected and how.}

Fill-in help: Pick a moment where something wasn't working for a person or group. Three senses max. No backstory yet.

Paragraph 2: What I did [~100 words]

I {insert active verb: organized/built/proposed} {insert what you did}, because {insert reason tied to a person, not an abstract value}. {Insert number: how many people, hours, dollars, devices}. Then {insert the setback: who said no, what broke, what failed}. So I {insert your workaround, an action with a verb}.

Fill-in help: Use the BEABIES questions. Keep your individual role clear: 'I' for what you did, 'we' for what the group did.

Paragraph 3: Impact and what I learned [~70 words]

By {insert time}, {insert measurable result}. {Insert one sentence about a specific person's reaction or a change you saw.} What I learned was {insert lesson in plain words}, {insert one concrete way you now behave differently}.

Paragraph 4: Forward to Michigan [~60 words]

At Michigan, I'll {insert specific action: join/start/bring} {insert named Michigan group, center or program, e.g., a student org, service center, project team} to {insert the contribution}. {Insert closing image that echoes your opening, e.g., the same object or place, changed.}

Check: Does it say 'prepared' (past evidence) and 'contribute' (future plan)? Does a reader know what you *did*, not just what you care about?

ESSAY #2 TEMPLATE — Why Michigan Engineering (target 530-550 words)

Paragraph 1: Origin scene [~80 words]

{Insert sensory opening: sound, smell, material, tool}. I was {insert what you were building/fixing/testing, and your age or year}, {insert one detail of what went wrong or what you noticed}. {Insert the question it raised, e.g., 'Why does X fail when Y?'}

Paragraph 2: Thesis [~60 words]

That question is why I'm applying to the College of Engineering to study {insert major(s) or 'undecided between X and Y'}. I want to {insert goal: who benefits and how}, and I know I need {insert skills: hands-on design, systems thinking, research} to do it.

Fill-in help: Make the goal about people ('lower household energy costs', 'safer prosthetics'), not just 'solve problems.' You can be undecided; name one or two fields and say how you'd explore.

Paragraph 3: Curriculum specific #1 [~90 words]

In {insert exact first-year course or program, verified on engin.umich.edu}, I would {insert what you'd do}. {Insert the experience you already have that makes this the right next step, e.g., 'After building X, I'm ready for Y'}. {Insert one sentence on what you hope to be able to do afterward.}

Paragraph 4: Hands-on specific #2 [~90 words]

Beyond class, {insert named project team or lab, e.g., one of the student teams in the Wilson Student Team Project Center}, is where I'd {insert role: wiring, CAD, testing, outreach}. {Insert why this fits your past, with a number or detail}. {Insert how you would help the team, not only what you'd get}.

Paragraph 5: Research or faculty specific #3 [~70 words]

{Insert professor or lab name and the topic of their work, verified from their page}'s research on {insert topic} connects to my {insert your project or class}. I'd like to {insert how: UROP, ask to join, read papers} because {insert reason}.

Paragraph 6: Beyond engineering [~60 words]

Outside of engineering, I'd {insert non-engineering interest and a named Michigan outlet, e.g., a club, arts group, intramural, service org}, because {insert what it shows about you}.

Paragraph 7: Close [~60 words]

{Insert closing image echoing paragraph 1}. At Michigan, I want to {insert specific mission} alongside people who {insert quality: build, test, serve, argue}. I'm ready to {insert verb phrase}.

Check: Name-swap test passes? Every resource has a 'because'? Does it feel like *you* and not a brochure? Is a different college named anywhere by mistake?

Part 6. Michigan Engineering research checklist

Do this before filling the Essay #2 blanks. Spend an hour or more and collect 10 possibilities; use the 3-5 that connect to you. Verify everything on official pages.

- **Official start:** engin.umich.edu undergraduate pages; your intended department's page (e.g., ME, EECS, Aerospace, Chemical, Civil & Environmental, Industrial & Operations, Materials, Naval Arch., Biomedical).
- **First-year courses:** look up the first-year engineering sequence and any programming/design course for your major. Name the exact course titles.
- **Student teams and the Wilson Student Team Project Center:** a Michigan Daily article describes a 20,000 sq ft workshop with nearly 30 teams; Aerospace lists MRover (150+ students). Others reported by secondary sources include MAAV, UM::Autonomy, MRacing (Formula SAE), Michigan Electric Racing, Solar Car, M-Fly, Baja, and rocketry teams. **Confirm each on the official directory.**
- **Research:** search faculty pages in your department; read two abstracts; note the lab name. Look up UROP.
- **Honors, global and dual-degree options:** check preferred admission and dual-degree pages if relevant (e.g., Integrated Business and Engineering with Ross, mentioned in GradPilot's guide).
- **Community fit:** student orgs (service, design, outreach), the Ginsberg Center.
- **Contact:** if true, mention a campus visit, webinar or conversation with a student or rep.

Brainstorm worksheet (answer these before drafting)

- The first thing I built or fixed that mattered to me: {____}
- A person who benefited or whose problem I wanted to solve: {____}
- A time I failed or got told no, and what I did next: {____}
- Three sensory details of my best origin scene: {____}
- Three Michigan Engineering specifics and my 'because' for each: {____}
- What I'd contribute to a team, not just gain: {____}

Final checklist

- Essay #1 and #2 use **different** stories.
- Word counts: #1 <= 300, #2 <= 550 (check with the Michigan application counter).
- No rankings, weather or sports fandom.
- Every proper noun is spelled right and verified.
- No braces left. Read aloud; get one reader who knows you.
- Everything in it is true and yours. Model the structure and tone, not the sentences.

Sources

College Essay Guy: https://www.collegeessayguy.com/blog/university-michigan-supplemental-essay

AdmissionSight (UMich 2026-27, engineering and Prompt 1 samples): https://admissionsight.com/umich-supplemental-essays/

Quad Education Group: https://quadeducationgroup.com/blog/how-to-write-umich-supplemental-essays

CollegeVine (seven annotated examples): https://blog.collegevine.com/university-of-michigan-essay-examples/

CollegeVine FAQ tips: https://www.collegevine.com/faq/15599/any-tips-for-writing-the-why-umich-essay

CollegeAdvisor: https://www.collegeadvisor.com/essay-guides/university-of-michigan-supplemental-essays/

GradPilot (includes a constructed sample): https://gradpilot.com/news/umich-supplemental-essays-2026-2027

Crimson Education (UMich essays by a former admissions officer; page was rate-limited when I tried): https://crimsoneducation.org/ca/blog/university-of-michigan-supplemental-essays

Clastify engineering examples (blocked when I tried; check by hand): https://www.clastify.com/supplement/university-of-michigan-ann-arbor/why-this-college

English-for-Students engineering sample, Mark R. Eadie (blocked when I tried; check by hand): https://www.english-for-students.com/college-admission-essay-to-university-of-michigan.html

Michigan Engineering: https://engin.umich.edu (my fetch failed; verify directly)

Student teams reporting: https://news.engin.umich.edu/2022/10/engineers-are-made-on-student-teams and https://aero.engin.umich.edu/?p=1384

Summaries are paraphrased and quotes are limited to short excerpts. For full essay text, read the originals at the links above.